

Interpretation of Body Languages and Signals Recommended Postures for Professional Setting Tone and Tenor

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EYES

- Windows to the soul
- Notice direct eye contact, averting the gaze, blinking or pupils dilated

EYE GAZE

- When looking directly into the eyes during a conversation, it indicates that they are interested and paying attention. However, prolonged eye contact can feel threatening.
- On the other hand, breaking eye contact and frequently looking away might indicate that the person is distracted, uncomfortable, or trying to conceal his or her real feelings.

BLINKING

- Blinking is natural, but you should also pay attention to whether a person is blinking too much or too little.
- People often blink more rapidly when they are feeling distressed or uncomfortable. Infrequent blinking may indicate that a person is intentionally trying to control his or her eye movements.⁷
- For example, a poker player might blink less frequently because he is purposely trying to appear unexcited about the hand he was dealt.

PUPIL SIZE

- Pupil size can be a very subtle nonverbal communication signal. While light levels in the environment control pupil dilation, sometimes emotions can also cause small changes in pupil size.
- For example, you may have heard the phrase "bedroom eyes" used to describe the look someone gives when they are attracted to another person. Highly dilated eyes, for example, can indicate that a person is interested.⁸

MOUTH

- Mouth expressions and movements can also be essential in reading body language. For example, chewing on the bottom lip may indicate that the individual is experiencing feelings of worry, fear, or insecurity.
- Covering the mouth may be an effort to be polite if the person is yawning or coughing, but it may also be an attempt to cover up a frown of disapproval.
- Smiling is perhaps one of the greatest body language signals, but smiles can also be interpreted in many ways.
- A smile may be genuine, or it may be used to express false happiness, sarcasm, or even cynicism.⁹

- When evaluating body language, pay attention to the following mouth and lip signals:
- **Pursed lips.** Tightening the lips might be an indicator of distaste, disapproval, or distrust.
- **Lip biting.** People sometimes bite their lips when they are worried, anxious, or stressed.
- **Covering the mouth.** When people want to hide an emotional reaction, they might cover their mouths in order to avoid displaying smiles or smirks.
- **Turned up or down.** Slight changes in the mouth can also be subtle indicators of what a person is feeling. When the mouth is slightly turned up, it might mean that the person is feeling happy or optimistic. On the other hand, a slightly down-turned mouth can be an indicator of sadness, disapproval, or even an outright grimace.

GESTURES

- Gestures can be some of the most direct and obvious body language signals. Waving, pointing, and using the fingers to indicate numerical amounts are all very common and easy to understand gestures.
- Some gestures may be [cultural](#), however, so giving a thumbs-up or a peace sign in another country might have a completely different meaning than it does in the United States.

- The following examples are just a few common gestures and their possible meanings:
- **A clenched fist** can indicate anger in some situations or solidarity in others.
- **A thumbs up and thumbs down** are often used as gestures of approval and disapproval.¹⁰
- **The "okay" gesture**, made by touching together the thumb and index finger in a circle while extending the other three fingers can be used to mean "okay" or "all right."¹⁰ In some parts of Europe, however, the same signal is used to imply you are nothing. In some South American countries, the symbol is actually a vulgar gesture.
- **The V sign**, created by lifting the index and middle finger and separating them to create a V-shape, means peace or victory in some countries. In the United Kingdom and Australia, the symbol takes on an offensive meaning when the back of the hand is facing outward.

ARMS & LEGS

- The arms and legs can also be useful in conveying nonverbal information. Crossing the arms can indicate defensiveness. Crossing legs away from another person may indicate dislike or discomfort with that individual.
- Other subtle signals such as expanding the arms widely may be an attempt to seem larger or more commanding, while keeping the arms close to the body may be an effort to minimize oneself or withdraw from attention.

- When you are evaluating body language, pay attention to some of the following signals that the arms and legs may convey:¹
- **Crossed arms** might indicate that a person feels defensive, self-protective, or closed-off.¹
- **Standing with hands placed on the hips** can be an indication that a person is ready and in control, or it can also possibly be a sign of [aggressiveness](#).
- **Clasping the hands behind the back** might indicate that a person is feeling bored, anxious, or even angry.
- **Rapidly tapping fingers or fidgeting** can be a sign that a person is bored, impatient, or frustrated.
- **Crossed legs** can indicate that a person is feeling closed-off or in need of privacy.

POSTURE

- How we hold our bodies can also serve as an important part of body language.
- The term *posture* refers to how we hold our bodies as well as the overall physical form of an individual.
- Posture can convey a wealth of information about how a person is feeling as well as hints about personality characteristics, such as whether a person is confident, open, or submissive.
- Sitting up straight, for example, may indicate that a person is focused and paying attention to what's going on. Sitting with the body hunched forward, on the other hand, can imply that the person is bored or indifferent.

- When you are trying to read body language, try to notice some of the signals that a person's posture can send.
- **Open posture** involves keeping the trunk of the body open and exposed. This type of posture indicates friendliness, openness, and willingness.¹¹
- **Closed posture** involves hiding the trunk of the body often by hunching forward and keeping the arms and legs crossed. This type of posture can be an indicator of hostility, unfriendliness, and anxiety.¹¹

PERSONAL SPACE

- Have you ever heard someone refer to their need for personal space? Have you ever started to feel uncomfortable when someone stands just a little too close to you?
- The term *proxemics*, coined by anthropologist Edward T. Hall, refers to the distance between people as they interact. Just as body movements and facial expressions can communicate a great deal of nonverbal information, so can the physical space between individuals.

4 levels of social distance

- Intimate
- Personal
- Social
- Public

Intimate Distance: 6 to 18 inches

- This level of physical distance often indicates a closer relationship or greater comfort between individuals.

Personal Distance: 1.5 to 4 feet

- Physical distance at this level usually occurs between people who are family members or close friends. The closer the people can comfortably stand while interacting can be an indicator of the level of intimacy in their relationship.

Social Distance: 4 to 12 feet

- This level of physical distance is often used with individuals who are acquaintances.
- With someone you know fairly well, such as a co-worker you see several times a week, you might feel more comfortable interacting at a closer distance.
- In cases where you do not know the other person well, such as a postal delivery driver you only see once a month, a distance of 10 to 12 feet may feel more comfortable.

Public Distance: 12 to 25 feet

- Physical distance at this level is often used in public speaking situations. Talking in front of a class full of students or giving a presentation at work are good examples of such situations.
- It is also important to note that the level of personal distance that individuals need to feel comfortable can vary from culture to culture.
- One oft-cited example is the difference between people from Latin cultures and those from North America. People from Latin countries tend to feel more comfortable standing closer to one another as they interact, while those from North America need more personal distance.

POSTURE FOR A FORMAL SETTING

Recommended posture

- The key points to remember regarding the ideal position to sit at work are:
- Keep your back straight, in particular:
 - Avoid rounding your shoulders forward (for this, you must have your screen at your eye level)
 - Avoid rounding (or arching) your lower back
- Keep your shoulders relaxed and back
- Place your elbows so that they form an angle of 90-100 degrees (never less)
- Keep your knees at a height of your hips (the thighs should form an angle of 90-100 degrees with the torso)
- Leave your legs relaxed, bent at about 90-100 degrees, leave your feet resting on the ground and do not cross your legs.

Tone & Tenor

Tone & tenor

- Tenor=what you say
- Tone=how you say it
- refer to the overall mood and attitude expressed by a piece of writing
- E.g.: The article had a very somber tone and tenor, befitting the sadness of the event it described.